

The district with the lowest population density in the country is the Mullaitivu District, where the figure stands at 51 persons per square kilometer in 2024. In Mullaitivu, Mannar, Vavuniya, and Moneragala Districts, the number of persons per square kilometer is fewer than 100.

3.5 Distribution of Population by Sector

In the Census of Population and Housing-2012 information was collected by classifying the country into three sectors Urban, Rural, and Estate. However, in the Census of Population and Housing - 2024, this classification was further expanded into four sectors: Urban, Rural, Estate Urban, and Estate Rural. (Definitions of these four sectors are provided under paragraph 1.2).

Areas identified as “Estate Urban” in the 2024 Census were included under the “Urban Sector” in the 2012 Census. Similarly, the “Estate Sector” identified in the 2012 Census corresponds to the “Estate Rural” sector in the 2024 Census. The identification of the “Rural” sector remains unchanged between the 2012 and 2024 censuses.

Table 3.5 : Distribution of Population by Sector, 2012 and 2024

Sector	2012		2024	
	Number	Percentage	Number	Percentage
Sri Lanka	20,359,439	100.0	21,781,800	100.0
Urban*	3,704,470	18.2	3,819,203	17.5
Rural	15,753,322	77.4	17,096,918	78.5
Estate Rural**	901,647	4.4	865,679	4.0

*In 2024 information was collected separately for "Urban" and "Estate Urban" sectors, for comparison with the 2012 Census data, these two sectors have been combined and presented as "Urban".

** In the 2012 Census, the sector was identified as “Estate”, whereas in the 2024 Census it is referred to as “Estate Rural”.

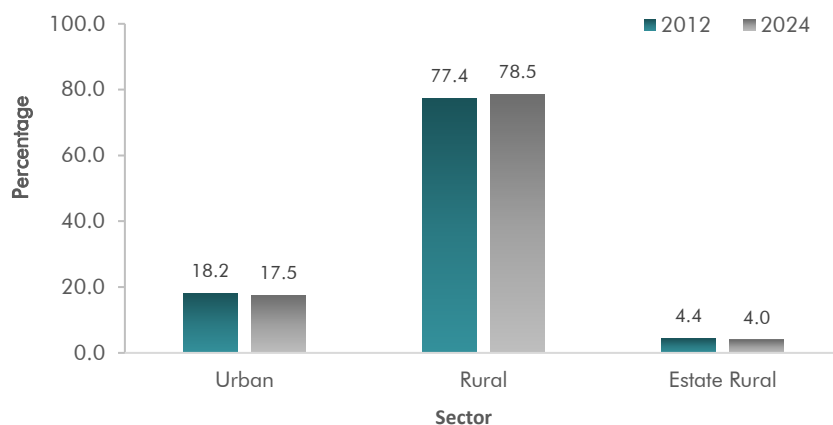


Figure 3.2 : Distribution of Population by Sector, 2012 and 2024

According to the Census of Population and Housing 2012, the population in the urban sector was 3,704,470, which accounted for 18.2 percent of the total population. In the current census, the urban sector population is 3,819,203, representing 17.5 percent of the total population. Compared to the 2012 census, the urban population in this census shows a decrease of 0.7 percentage points.